

Fit is the whole game

Week 7, Lecture 1 · Looksmaxxing

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What we will cover

- Why fit outranks brand, color, and price every time
- The four-point fit check: shoulder, chest, sleeve, pant rise/break
- Tailoring 101: what is alterable, what is not, and what it costs
- Body proportions: dressing the frame you have now
- What a rotating wardrobe looks like in a small closet

Part 1: the four-point fit check

Fit before everything else

- A \$40 shirt that fits looks better than a \$400 shirt that does not.
- Most men's fit problems are concentrated at two points: the shoulder and the pant rise.
- Fix those two and 80% of the work is done.
- Centeno (Real Men Real Style, 2022): each fit-check video isolates one point with before/after comparisons because one point at a time is how you actually build the skill.

The shoulder seam: the non-negotiable

- The shoulder seam should sit right at the edge of your natural shoulder, where the slope toward your arm begins.
- Seam on the upper arm: the garment is too large. Seam pulled toward the neck: too small.
- **Why it matters:** the shoulder seam is the structural anchor of a jacket or shirt. Every other measurement cascades from it.
- Sacawa (He Spoke Style, 2022): “The shoulder seam is the one structural point that cannot be altered by a tailor without a complete rebuild.”
- Consequence: a failing shoulder is almost always a cull, not a tailor.

The chest: how much room is right

- With arms at your sides, you should be able to pinch roughly one inch of fabric on each side.
- Too tight: pulling across the chest, button stress, armhole restriction.
- Too loose: boxy silhouette, shoulder seam slipping outward.
- Chest width can be taken in by a tailor; letting out a too-small chest requires enough seam allowance in the original garment.
- Check both the front and the back: a shirt can fit fine at the front and pull across the shoulder blades.

Sleeve length

- Dress shirt or casual button-up: sleeve hem at the base of the thumb when the arm hangs naturally.
- T-shirt: sleeve hem at or just below mid-bicep.
- Sleeves that are too long make you look shorter; sleeves that are too short make the arms look thick.
- Shortening sleeves is one of the cheapest alterations a tailor does. Lengthening requires seam allowance.

Pant rise and pant break

- **Rise** is the distance from the crotch seam to the waistband. Low-rise pants sit below the hip bone; mid-rise sits at it; high-rise sits above.
- Low-rise on a longer torso creates a short-legged look. High-rise on a short torso visually crops the torso further.
- **Break** is how much the trouser leg rests on the shoe: full break (fabric bunches), half break (slight fold), no break (clean hem above the shoe).
- Most modern fits use half break or no break. Full break reads as dated unless the trouser is deliberately wide-leg.
- Centeno (Real Men Real Style, 2022): pant rise is frequently ignored but has an outsized effect on perceived leg length.

Part 2: tailoring basics

What a tailor can and cannot fix

- **Can alter:** chest width (taking in), sleeve length (shortening), trouser length and break, trouser waist (in or out), shirt hem length.
- **Cannot easily alter (or very expensive):** shoulder seam, jacket chest when too small, trouser thighs when too small.
- The cascade rule: if the shoulder does not fit, nothing else is worth altering. Start there.

Alteration costs (ballpark)

- Shorten sleeves: \$15-25
- Take in shirt side seams: \$20-40
- Shorten trouser hem: \$10-20
- Take in trouser waist: \$15-30
- Move shoulder seam: \$150-300+ (often not worth it)
- Decision rule: if the alteration costs more than 30% of replacement cost, buy a garment that fits from the start.

Part 3: body proportions and rotating wardrobes

Dressing for your proportions

- Every body has a natural shoulder-to-waist-to-hip ratio.
- The goal of fit is to create a balanced silhouette, not to change your actual proportions.
- Broad shoulders and narrow hips: avoid shoulder pads, favor slim-cut trousers to balance.
- Narrow shoulders and wider hips: structured shoulders help; avoid tapered trousers that emphasize the hip.
- Shorter torso: avoid low-rise; mid-rise or high-rise visually lengthens the leg line.
- Longer torso: avoid high-rise that further shortens the visual leg; mid-rise is safer.

Vertical balance: the stack matters

- Your outfit reads from the top down. Loose top over slim trousers reads balanced. Slim top over wide trousers also reads balanced.
- Loose top over loose trousers reads unstructured. This is not always wrong, but it requires intention.
- The fit check applies to the full stack, not each garment in isolation.
- Sacawa (He Spoke Style, 2022): fit is about how clothing relates to your body as a whole, not garment by garment.

What a rotating wardrobe looks like

- A rotating wardrobe is not a large wardrobe. It is a small wardrobe where every item fits and is worn regularly.
- Rotating means each item has a role in at least two looks in your capsule plan.
- Items that have not been worn in six months and do not belong to a capsule look are candidates for culling.
- The section worksheet uses this logic: photograph, score, keep/tailor/cull.

Fit is not about fashion or trends. It is about proportion and how clothing relates to your body. The shoulder seam is the one structural point that cannot be altered by a tailor without a complete rebuild.

<footer>Brian Sacawa, He Spoke Style, "The Ultimate Guide For How Your Clothes Should Fit" (2022)</footer>

Take-aways

1. The shoulder seam is the single most important fit point. If it fails, the garment is almost always a cull, not a tailor job.
2. The four-point check covers everything else: chest room, sleeve length, pant rise and break. Two or more fails means reassess.
3. Alterations are cheap for length and width but very expensive for structure. Learn which is which before you buy anything.
4. Body proportions are about balance. Dress to create a balanced silhouette, not to hide anything.
5. A small wardrobe where everything fits is worth more than a large one where most things do not.

What's next

- **Lecture 2 (this week):** Color theory, undertone, the three-color rule, and how to build a five-look capsule on \$300
- **Reading:** Week 7 reading covers both lectures and sets you up for the section worksheet and HW4
- **Section (this week):** Tinder-style wardrobe audit: photograph every top, run the fit check, cull
- **HW4 (out this week):** Five-look capsule wardrobe plan, due Week 9
- **Capstone (also out this week):** Personal twelve-week plan and before-and-after, due Week 10